Topic 10 — Post-Gupta Period

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Post-Gupta Age | Harshavardhana | Administration of Harsha | Policies of Harshavardhana | Banabhatta | Harshacharita | Hiuen Tsang | I-tsing | Hunas | After-Harsha Kannauj pointer

Sources baked in: Bana, *Si-Yu-Ki*, Aihole, Banskhera, Sung-yun, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — 2024 traveller order, 2022 Maukhari/later-Gupta pairs, Harsha–Pulakeshin, textiles & feudal note **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — static

Books and Writers — Post-Gupta / Harsha Age

Book–writer pairs | Bana, Harsha's plays, Chinese travellers

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Harshacharita	**Banabhatta**	Prose biography (*akhyayika*) of Harsha
Kadambari	**Banabhatta** (finished by **Bhushanabhatta**)	Prose romance (*katha*)
Suryashataka	**Mayura**	Same Harsha court; not Bana
Nagananda, *Ratnavali*, *Priyadarshika*	Attributed to **Harsha**	Court plays; *Nagananda* has Buddhist flavour
Si-Yu-Ki (*Xiyu Ji*)	**Hiuen Tsang / Xuanzang**	Chinese record of Harsha's India
Nanhai Jigui Neifa Zhuan	**I-tsing (Yijing)**	Post-Harsha Nalanda / sea-route account
Kitab-ul-Hind	**Al-Biruni**	~1017; last in the usual traveller order
Rajatarangini	**Kalhana** (कल्हण)	Later Kashmir chronicle (Huna / Harsha-age memory)

- **Banabhatta** wrote *Harshacharita* and *Kadambari*. **Mayura** wrote *Suryashataka*.
- Traveller order for match stems: Fa-Hien → Hiuen Tsang → I-tsing → Al-Biruni (Fa-Hien is Gupta-age; taught in Topic 9).

Logic: Full Banabhatta and Xuanzang cards stay below.

10.1 Post-Gupta Age

~550–647 CE | Hunas then regional houses | Harsha is a reunion, not a Gupta

- The imperial Gupta centre dies in the mid-6th century. The **Hunas** are led first by **Toramana**, then by **Mihirakula**. Mihirakula's remembered seat is **Sakala** (Sialkot). The **Gwalior** inscription names him. The **Rajatarangini** remembers him in Kashmir. The **Eran** boar inscription names Toramana.
- **Yashodharman** of Malwa boasts the Huna check at **Mandasor** (Dashapura), about **532 CE**. **Vasula** is the composer remembered for the **Sondani / Sondhni** record of that victory.
- The **Pushyabhuti / Vardhana** house sits at **Thanesar** in Haryana. Founder-memory is **Pushyabhuti**. This is Harsha's family.
- The **Maukharis** sit at **Kannauj** in Uttar Pradesh. They rise as earlier Gupta feudatories from the Gaya belt, and the last Maukhari name in the Harsha story is **Grihavarman**.
- The Maukhari line in papers runs Hariavarman / Adityavarman memory, then Ishvaravarman, Ishanavarman, Sarvavarman, Avantivarman, and Grihavarman.
- The **Later Guptas** sit in Magadha. **Adityasena** has the **Aphsad** inscription in Bihar, and the end-name is **Jivitagupta II**.
- The **Maitrakas** sit at **Valabhi** in Gujarat. Founder-memory is **Bhatarka**.
- **Gauda** is Bengal under **Shashanka**, with capital **Karnasuvarna**.
- The **Chalukyas of Badami** under **Pulakeshin II** hold **Vatapi** and later stop Harsha at the Narmada.
- Between Gupta fall and Harsha, power in the north also sits with Later Guptas, Pushyabhutis, Maukharis, and Maitrakas — **not** with later houses such as Paramaras of Malwa or Yadavas of Devagiri.
- **Harsha-samvat** starts in **606 CE**.
- **Ishanavarman — Haraha** is **correct**. It is Barabanki, UP. VS 611 / **554 CE**.
- **Ishvaravarman — Jaunpur stone** is **correct** in that paper. He is father of Ishanavarman.
- **Jivitagupta II — Deo-Baranark** is **correct**. It is Bhojpur, Bihar.
- **Sarvavarman — Gaya copper plate** is **NOT matched**. The Gaya plate is Gupta / **Samudragupta**. Sarvavarman is the **Asirgarh** seal.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q87]:** Dynastic capitals: Maukhari = Kannauj; Pushyabhuti = Thaneshwar / Kannauj; Maitraka = Vallabhi; Gauda = Karnasuvarna. *(See Q2 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

- After **647** the north splits again. Kannauj becomes the later prize of the **tripartite struggle** among **Gurjara-Pratihara**, **Pala**, and **Rashtrakuta** (राष्ट्रकूट). That full story — Nagabhata I, Dantidurga's Hiranyagarbha, Amoghavarsha I, Dharmapala — lives in the Early Medieval Regional Kingdoms chapter. Keep only the pointer here.

> **Logic:** Harsha is **Pushyabhuti**, not a Gupta emperor.

10.2 Harshavardhana

Pushyabhuti | r. 606–647 CE | last big ancient north-Indian king

- Father is **Prabhakaravardhana**. Mother is **Yasomati**. Elder brother **Rajyavardhana** is killed by **Shashanka** of Gauda.
- Sister **Rajyashri** married Maukhari **Grihavarman** of Kannauj. Shashanka's side kills Grihavarman and holds Rajyashri.
- Harsha takes the Thanesar throne about **606**. He rescues Rajyashri and unites Thanesar and Kannauj.
- The early capital is **Thanesar** (**Sthaneshvara**, Haryana). The later capital is **Kannauj** (**Kanyakubja**, Uttar Pradesh).
- The Chinese title is **Siladitya**. Other titles are Maharajadhiraja and Paramabhattaraka. Family memory starts Shaiva. Later he is a loud **Buddhist patron**. He still hosts Brahmans.
- The east ally is **Bhaskaravarman** of Kamarupa.
- Three plays are often given to him: *Nagananda*, *Ratnavali*, and *Priyadarshika*. *Nagananda* carries the Buddhist flavour of the three.
- The **Banskhera** copper plate carries Harsha's **signature**. The **Madhuban** copper plate is the other Harsha grant fact. The **Sonpat** seal is Pushyabhuti family. A **Nalanda** seal of Harsha also exists.
- He dies about **647**. There is no stable heir. After 647 the Chinese envoy **Wang Xuance** comes. **Arunashva** of Tirhut attacks him.
- Written sources are court poet **Banabhatta** (*Harshacharita*) and the Chinese pilgrim **Hiuen Tsang** (*Si-Yu-Ki*).
- **Harshavardhan** is a common trap option for **Hathigumpha**. The inscription belongs to **Kharavela** of Kalinga, not Harsha.

> **Logic:** Thanesar is not Kannauj. Kannauj is the UP fact.

10.3 Administration of Harsha

Gupta titles reused | personal rule | feudal land control | collapses when he dies

- This is not a new machine. **Bhukti / Vishaya** titles continue from Gupta. The **uparika** is still the provincial governor. The **mahasandhivigrahika** is the peace-and-war / foreign minister. The **mahapratihara** is palace / chamberlain. The **bhandagaradhikarana** is the treasury. The **rajasthaniya** is a court or provincial deputy in some grants.
- **Mahasamanta** feudatories sit under him. The grip is less tight than Mauryan amatyas. Agrahara grants to Brahmans go on. The court can move as a camp (**skandhavara**).
- Post-Gupta political economy shows clearer **feudal** features: land-based lord–vassal ties, dependent peasantry around grants, and weak provincial centres when the personal king dies.
- Xuanzang praises roads and access to the king, but also notes robbery on routes and harsh ordeals. Elephant numbers in the *Si-Yu-Ki* are colour, not a census. The weak point is that the state **is Harsha**. 647 proves it.

- Trade credit in the post-Harsha sources remembers **hundi** as a bill of exchange, not a royal edict.

> **Logic:** He did not invent Uparika. That is Gupta vocabulary.

10.4 Policies of Harshavardhana

Digvijaya in the north | Narmada is the southern wall | charity plus assembly

Harsha tries to reunite north India after the Guptas. He succeeds in the north and west. He fails to become a Deccan emperor.

Religious assemblies (Uttar Pradesh angle)

- The **Kannauj assembly of 643 CE** honours **Xuanzang (Hiuen Tsang)** and advertises Mahayana patronage.
- Tributary kings, including **Bhaskaravarman** of Kamarupa, and large numbers of Buddhist, Jaina, and Vedic scholars attend that assembly.
- The **Prayag Mahamoksha Parishad** is Harsha's quinquennial charity assembly at the **Triveni Sangam**.
- Xuanzang witnesses the **sixth** Mahamoksha gathering in **643 CE**.
- Coaching memory stresses that Harsha gives away accumulated treasury wealth, including jewels and garments, and takes plain cloth from his sister **Rajyashri**.

East — Shashanka

- The early aim is to punish **Shashanka** of Gauda.
- The east ally against Gauda is **Bhaskaravarman** of Kamarupa.
- Gauda is weakened. Shashanka dies about **637 CE**.

West — Valabhi

- In the west he reaches Punjab, Rajasthan, and Gujarat.
- Maitraka **Dhruvasena II** of Valabhi is restored as an ally.
- **Rajyashri did not marry Dhruvasena.** She is Grihavarman's widow.

South — Pulakeshin II (Cause, Course, Result)

Cause: Harsha pushed south from Kannauj and tried to cross into the Deccan.

Course: **Pulakeshin II** of **Vatapi** stopped him about **630–634 CE**. The **Aihole inscription** of **Ravikirti** on the **Meguti** temple records that boast. Some copper-plate readings push the clash toward **618 CE**; the stopper remains Pulakeshin II.

Result: The **Narmada** becomes Harsha's effective southern line. He never becomes a Deccan emperor.

Assemblies and charity

- The Kannauj **assembly of 643** honours Xuanzang. Rulers from many lands attend; Mahayana is foregrounded.
- The **Prayag Moksha-parishad / Mahamoksha** is held every five years at the Sangam. Xuanzang sees one of these give-aways.
- An embassy goes to Tang **Taizong** about **641**.

Economy and faith notes

- Chinese writers call India **Yin-tu**.
- Silk can appear as **kausheya**.
- Xuanzang notes **Mathura** for cotton cloth and **Varanasi** for silk.
- Thanesar's prosperity is trade-based.
- Chinese report a slaughter ban in his lands.
- Faith is Buddhist patronage without wiping out Hindu cults.

> **Logic:** The Narmada stop is not the Battle of Kannauj 1540 (Sher Shah / Humayun).

10.5 Banabhatta

Harsha's court poet | Sanskrit prose | Pritikuta tradition

- Brahman. Village **Pritikuta** on the Son (Aurangabad, Bihar tradition; notes also place him in the Shravasti belt). Father **Chitrabhanu**. He wandered as a scholar, then entered **Harsha's court** as *asthana-kavi*. That is why he is a **source for Harsha**, not a Gupta-age poet.
- *Rajatarangini* of **Kalhana** also carries later memory useful for this age, but Bana is the court witness.
- He writes ornate **Sanskrit prose** (*gadya-kavya*). Verse-drama is not his identity.
- ***Harshacharita*** (हर्षचरित) is "Deeds of Harsha," a prose **biography** of his patron. Class: **akhyayika** (आख्यायिका).
- ***Kadambari*** (कादंबरी) is a long **romance** named after the heroine. Class: **katha** (कथा). Not a second Harsha chronicle. He left it unfinished. Tradition: son **Bhushanabhatta** (भूषणभट्ट) finished it.
- Same Harsha court also had **Mayura** (मयूर), author of *Suryashataka* (सूर्यशतक). Mayura is not Bana.
- **Banabhatta** (बाणभट्ट) is Harsha's **7th-century** court poet. **Kalidasa** (कालिदास) is Chandragupta II's (चंद्रगुप्त द्वितीय) Gupta-age poet.

> **Logic:** Bana ≠ Kalidasa. *Harshacharita* ≠ *Kadambari*.

10.6 Harshacharita

Bana's biography of Harsha | the book you use for the family story

- Sanskrit prose. Title means **Deeds of Harsha**.
- This is the *Harshacharita* named under Banabhatta above. Not a Gupta kavya.
- Eight chapters called ***ucchvasas***.
- **Ucchvasa 1** = Bana's own life (rare author-autobiography).
- Then the **Pushyabhuti** line: Prabhakaravardhana, Rajyavardhana's murder, Harsha's accession, rescue of Rajyashri.
- The **first four** ucchvasas carry almost all the usable political history.
- He stops before the full later reign. Pulakeshin, Kannauj 643 and the Prayag charity are told more fully by the Chinese pilgrim and by the copper plates.
- Court praise sits next to fact. Cross-check names with Banskhera / Madhuban.
- *Kadambari* is his other book — a prose romance. *Harshacharita* is the royal biography.

> **Logic:** *Harshacharita* = 7th c. biography. *Kadambari* = romance. *Si-Yu-Ki* = the Chinese record, not Bana.

10.7 Hiuen Tsang

Xuanzang | India ~630–644 | Harsha's Chinese witness

- He is also written **Xuanzang / Yuan Chwang**. He is a Tang monk. He left China in 629 from Chang'an. He is in India from **630**. The whole journey is often counted about 16 years.
- He studies at **Nalanda** under **Shilabhadra** (about 637 onward). He spends about **eight years** inside Harsha's lands. He calls Harsha **Siladitya**. He meets Harsha. The Kannauj assembly is **643**. He sees the **Prayag** (प्रयाग) charity.
- His book is the ***Si-Yu-Ki*** (*Xiyu Ji*, Records of the Western Regions). That is the Chinese witness. *Harshacharita* is the Sanskrit court witness. Use both. He is back in China in **645**. He translates sutras.
- Industry colour: **Mathura** is famous for **cotton** textiles; **Varanasi** for **silk**. Thanesar prospers from trade. Chinese name for India is **Yin-tu**.
- Roads and river routes are **not** free of robbery — Xuanzang himself was robbed. Ordeals by fire, water, and poison appear in his punishment notes. Tradesmen pay duties at ferries and barriers.
- **Fa-Hien** came two centuries earlier, under **Chandragupta II** (चंद्रगुप्त द्वितीय) (about 399–414), mainly for **Vinaya**. Xuanzang came for **Mahayana** texts. Nalanda itself was founded under **Kumaragupta I**. Xuanzang is the **visitor**, not the founder.
- **Sung-yun** (Song Yun) came about **518–521** under the Northern Wei — after Fa-Hien, before Xuanzang.
- **I-Tsing** comes by **sea** after Harsha (about 671–695). He is still at Nalanda. He is not Harsha's guest. **Al-Biruni** writes ***Kitab-ul-Hind*** under Mahmud (about 1017). He is last in the 2024 list.
- In ascending order: **Fa-Hien** (~399–414) → **Sung-yun** (~518–521) → **Hiuen Tsang** (~630–644) → **I-Tsing** (~671–695) → **Al-Biruni** (~1017).

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q149]:** Chronology of travellers: Faxian (Gupta) → Xuanzang (Harsha) → Yijing (Post-Harsha). *(See Q1 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** Hiuen Tsang ≠ Fa-Hien. Nalanda founder = **Kumaragupta I**. Xuanzang = visitor under Harsha.

10.8 I-tsing (Yijing) — Post-Harsha Chinese Traveller

~671–695 CE | sea route | Nalanda after Harsha

- I-tsing is a Tang monk who left China with associates about **671–672**.
- He reached India by the **western sea route** and returned to China about **693–694** via **Sumatra**.
- He is **not** Harsha's guest at the 643 Kannauj assembly.
- He studied and taught at **Nalanda** and records a large monk body at peak with detailed Vinaya practice.
- His book tradition is ***Nanhai Jigui Neifa Zhuan***.
- Traveller chronology is Fa-Hien (~400) → Hiuen Tsang (~630) → **I-tsing (~670s)** → Al-Biruni (~1017).

10.9 Nalanda in the Harsha Age

- Nalanda was founded under **Kumaragupta I** in the Gupta age. Harsha is a later **patron**, not the founder.
- **Hiuen Tsang** studies under **Shilabhadra** at Nalanda and spends years in Magadha recording campus life, libraries, and debate.
- The **Kannauj assembly of 643** honours Xuanzang and foregrounds Mahayana texts under Harsha's patronage.
- Final destruction of Nalanda is medieval — the army of **Bakhtiyar Khalji** about **1193**. That end belongs to the Pala–Sena age, not Harsha's lifetime.

10.10 After Harsha — Kannauj Pointer

- After **647**, Kannauj (also called **Mahodaya**) becomes the later north-Indian prize when no stable Pushyabhuti heir holds the centre.
- The **tripartite struggle** of the 8th–9th centuries is among **Gurjara-Pratihara**, **Pala**, and **Rashtrakuta**.
- Headline names for that later Early Medieval file include Pratihara **Nagabhata I**, Rashtrakuta **Dantidurga** (Hiranyagarbha at Ujjain; capital Manyakheta), **Amoghavarsha I**, and Pala **Dharmapala** (धर्मपाल).
- This chapter stops at the pointer; dynasty depth belongs with Early Medieval regional houses.
- Shankaracharya's Advaita maths and Chardham traps belong with Bhakti / Vedanta notes, not this Harsha card.

10.11 Hunas in Post-Gupta North

After Skandagupta | Toramana → Mihirakula | Yashodharman stops them

Cause

- Later Guptas were weak after Skandagupta.
- The northwest gateway stayed open to Huna pressure.

Course

- **Toramana** is the early Huna king who pushes into north India.
- **Mihirakula** follows him. The Gwalior inscription remembers him. His seat is at **Sakala**.
- **Yashodharman** of Malwa boasts victory at **Mandasor / Sondani** about **532 CE**. The composer is **Vasula**.

Result

- Huna power fades by the mid-6th century.
- North India stays fragmented until **Harsha** (606–647 CE).

10.14 Master Calendar & Eras Reference

Era / Samvat	Starting Year	Founder / Association	Key Conversion Formula
Kali Era	**3102 BCE**	Traditional Mahabharata epoch	Ancient astronomical reckonings
Vikrama Samvat (Krit / Malav)	**57 / 58 BCE**	King Vikramaditya of Ujjain	Current Gregorian Year + 57 (e.g. 2026 + 57 = 2083)
Saka Samvat	**78 CE**	Kushana Emperor Kanishka	Current Gregorian Year - 78 (e.g. 2026 - 78 = 1948); difference with Vikrama is **135 years**
Gupta Era	**319 / 320 CE**	Chandragupta I	Reckoned from Chandragupta I's coronation
Harsha Era	**606 CE**	Harshavardhana	Accession of Harsha

- **Badami rock inscription** of Pulakeshin I dated Saka 465 = 465 + 78 + 58 = 601 Vikrama Samvat.
- **Chalukya inscription** dated Saka 556 = 556 + 78 = 634 CE.
- **Gadhaiya coins:** Sassanian-inspired silver coins circulated in western India during early medieval times.

UP Focus

Fact	Place
Kannauj	Later Harsha capital
Haraha inscription	Barabanki — Ishanavarman
Jaunpur stone	Ishvaravarman in the 2022 key
Prayag charity	Prayagraj — Xuanzang
Pritikuta / Shravasti	Bana's home
Thanesar	**Haryana**. Not UP
Deo-Baranark	Bihar — Jivitagupta II. Not a UP site
Aphsad inscription	Bihar — Adityasena. Not a UP site
Banskhera plate	Shahjahanpur, UP — Harsha grant with signature